



FIG. 1 Two motorcycle taxi drivers are soliciting a girl



FIG. 2 Two motorcycle taxi drivers are waiting for clients

Data

The data for the study involve information stemming from a combination of three different methods applied in Tianzhi. The first part involved a careful reading of all official police records of robbery against motorcycle taxi drivers in Tianzhi in 2006. Among other items, police records usually contain reported information about the time, location, situational context, economic loss, bodily harm and household registration (*hukou*) of victims. In order to ensure coding reliability, all data were coded by me. All official recorded robbery against motorcycle taxi driver cases were collected, producing a sample of 174 cases. Although the sample is not big, it does include all the cases reported in 2006 and reflects the total picture of official police records in one year.

The second set of data came from my fieldwork observation in Tianzhi. As there is no formal organization representing the motorcycle taxi industry in China, it is impossible



FIG. 3 Many motorcycle taxi drivers are waiting for clients in front of a hospital



FIG. 4 The slogan indicates that non-local license motorcycles are prohibited from the road

to know the exact number of motorcycle taxi drivers in Tianzhi. However, the provision of such an estimate is not the aim of the present study. The aim rather is to study the relative proportions of migrant and resident motorcycle taxi drivers and their distinctive routine (working) activities. In order to achieve this goal, I employed on-site observation to count the number of motorcycle taxi drivers at each hour from 7:00 in the morning to 24:00 at night at four selected observation sites in Tianzhi. These sites include a public square, a hospital and two bus stations. These places are typical sites where motorcycle taxi drivers waited for their clients. At each hour of the day, I counted all the motorcycle taxi drivers who were waiting. As mentioned before, migrant or resident

motorcycle taxi drivers are distinguished by their different motorcycle licenses.² The period of observation lasted for two weeks in August 2007. I obtained two sets of numbers in each observation site on each hour; 1,407 cases were collected altogether for analysis. In addition, when I was in my field trip to Tianzhi in 2006, 2007 and 2008, I took every opportunity to observe motorcycle taxi drivers' working activities whenever I needed to use a motorcycle taxi, which is now the main transportation vehicle in Tianzhi.

The third part of my data collection involved in-depth semi-structured interviews with motorcycle taxi drivers (31), police (eight) and other migrant workers (six). All in all, I had a total of 45 interviews. Since motorcycle taxi drivers are everywhere in Tianzhi, they were first approached on the street by myself and then recruited for interview with their consent. Police and other migrant workers were recruited through my personal contacts established in past research. All interviewees participated in the research voluntarily. All interviews were tape-recorded and transcribed for later analysis. Information that may have led to violations of personal privacy, such as names, was deleted from the transcripts and only the author has access to the tapes.

Plan of Analysis

I shall first disclose the high risk of robbery victimization for migrant motorcycle taxi drivers by comparing the proportions of migrants in the total population of taxi drivers with that in all robbery victims with data from observation and official police records. After that, different risks will be analysed in the framework of target attractiveness, guardianship and target exposure from lifestyle/routine activity theory. Then, the paper will discuss the motorcycle ban policy applied by local government and its impact on migrant workers' working activity and their chances of being robbed. I conclude by pointing out that, although lifestyle/routine activity theory can be fairly applied to robbery in contemporary urban China, some rather particular Chinese macro-structural factors should be addressed in the interpretation of how people's working activity and, by extension, the risk of victimization are shaped.

Result

The disproportionately high risk of robbery victimization of migrant motorcycle taxi drivers

From official police records, there were 174 cases of robbery against motorcycle taxi drivers in Tianzhi in 2006. Ninety-three per cent of the victims were migrants and only 7 per cent residents (Figure 5).³ However, my field observational data about taxi drivers show that migrants made up 52 per cent and residents made up 48 per cent of the motorcycle taxi industry (Figure 6). What is worth mentioning is that, because of their

²In China, each motorcycle must have a license, composed of seven characters. The first is a Chinese character, indicating the province in which the license is registered. The second character is a capital English letter, indicating which city in that province. The remaining five characters are Arabic numerals. From the first Chinese character and the second capital English letter, we can distinguish which city the motorcycle is from. As the migrants are not allowed to buy a Tianzhi license, we can tell who are migrants and residents from their motorcycle licenses.

³Although it is illegal for migrants to drive non-local license motorcycles, this illegal working status does not impede them from reporting their robbery cases to police, as they will get no punishment if they report the case. Reasons will be discussed later in detail in the paper when analysing campaign-style policing in China.

Robbery Victimization of Migrant/Resident Motorcycle Drivers (n=174)

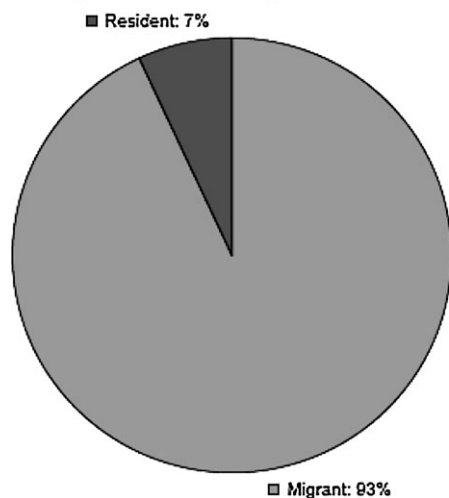


FIG. 5 Proportion of migrant/resident motorcycle taxi drivers in Tianzhi City

Proportion of Migrant/Resident Motor-taxi Drivers in Tianzhi City (n=1407)

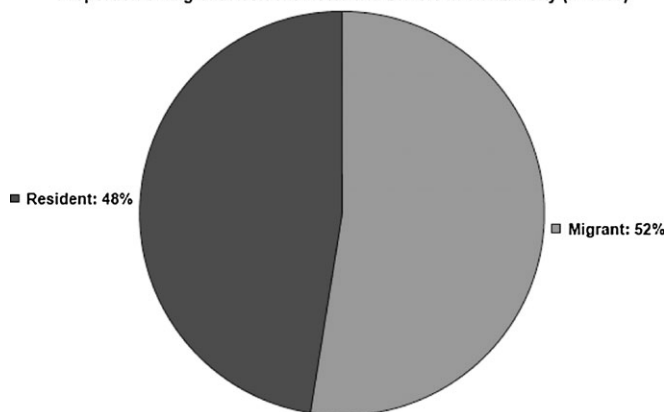


FIG. 6 Robbery victimization of migrant/resident motorcycle taxi drivers

illegal working status, a very small number of migrants might buy a local license or use a false local license. Although it is hard to find out the exact number of migrants who do so, my interview and observation data indicated that this number was quite small. Therefore, the actual proportion of migrant taxi drivers should be slightly higher than I observed. However, this minor measurement inaccuracy cannot contradict the obvious fact that migrants make up a large proportion of robbery victims, their rate of victimization being 12 times as great as that of the resident motorcycle taxi drivers.

Explanations derived from lifestyle/routine activity theory

I was interested in trying to examine whether lifestyle/routine activity theory could explain this difference. Let me consider the three components of the theory in turn.

As for target attractiveness, lifestyle/routine activity theory assumes that the greater the attractiveness of a target, the greater the risk of victimization (Cohen *et al.* 1981). For motorcycle taxi drivers, the motorcycle itself is a valuable target to be stolen, as it is valued at between 3,000 and 10,000 yuan.⁴ The drivers have cash on them because they are doing business. Mobile phones are also commonly used by people in cities in general and by motorcycle taxi drivers in particular, as some known clients will call motorcycle taxi drivers for service. All in all, motorcycles, cash and mobile phones can be targets for robbery. However, from my field observations, it is clear that there is no big difference between migrants and residents regarding these targets, as they use similar motorcycles, similar mobile phones and carry little money with them. It is therefore hard to find an explanation for the differential risks of robbery victimization in the variable of target attractiveness.

As to guardianship, lifestyle/routine activity theory assumes that offenders prefer targets that are less well guarded to those that are better guarded (Cohen *et al.* 1981). When a motorcycle taxi driver takes a client to a certain place, he must work by himself and away from other motorcycle taxi drivers who might provide help when he is in danger. Motorcycle taxi drivers will also be physically distant from the guardianship of police as well as other people on the road if clients ask them to go to some remote area. Official police records indicate that 42 and 37 per cent of robbery cases occur in rural and suburban areas and only 5 and 16 per cent of cases in cities and towns (Figure 7). Obviously, rural and suburban areas are less well guarded than cities and towns from police. This is especially the case at night. As Ganlao, a migrant motorcycle taxi driver from Hubei province, said:

It is very dangerous. At night, I will not go to these dark roads. Usually, I only go to the place we have reached an agreement before. After arriving, I will not go to another place. If he demands that I go to another place, even if I cannot get the money, I will not go. (Ganlao, 42)

In other words, different working hours will affect the level of guardianship confronting likely robbers. Those who work at a 'dangerous time' will run a higher risk of victimization than those who work at a 'safe time'. Because of the local government's motorcycle ban policy, migrants are obliged to work at night. Figure 8 shows this vividly. The reasons why migrant workers are relegated to working at relatively dangerous times will be explored in detail later in this paper.

As to target exposure, lifestyle/routine activity theory assumes that an increase in exposure will lead to an increase in victimization risk (Cohen *et al.* 1981). As long as motorcycle taxi drivers are picking up clients on the road, they will be exposed to potential robbers. This is especially the case when they work at night, as robbery tends to be a form of 'night' crime (Xu 2006b). As such, working at night will increase the chance of victimization, in terms of both exposure to likely offenders and the absence of capable guardianship. It is evident (from Figure 9) that night-time is the peak time for robbery against motorcycle taxi drivers and 77.58 per cent of motorcycle taxi robberies occur from 19:00 at night to 2:00 in the early morning.

⁴ 1 yuan = \$0.15 or £0.08 at September 2008 prices.

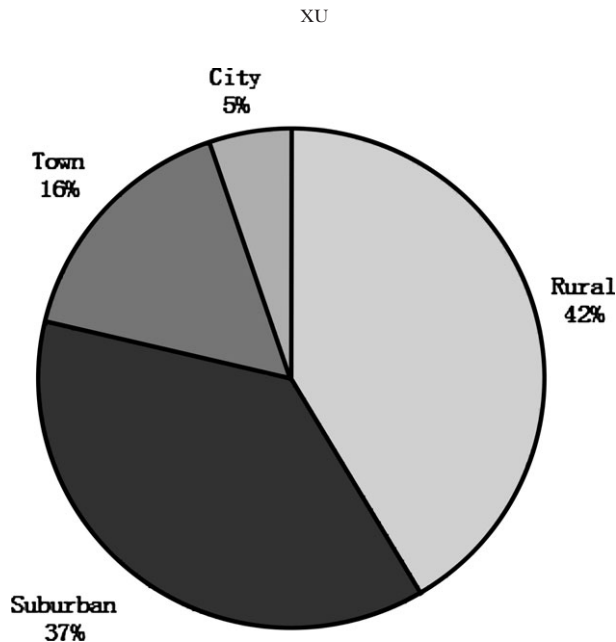


FIG. 7 Crime sites for robbery against motorcycle taxi drivers from police records in 2006 (n = 174)

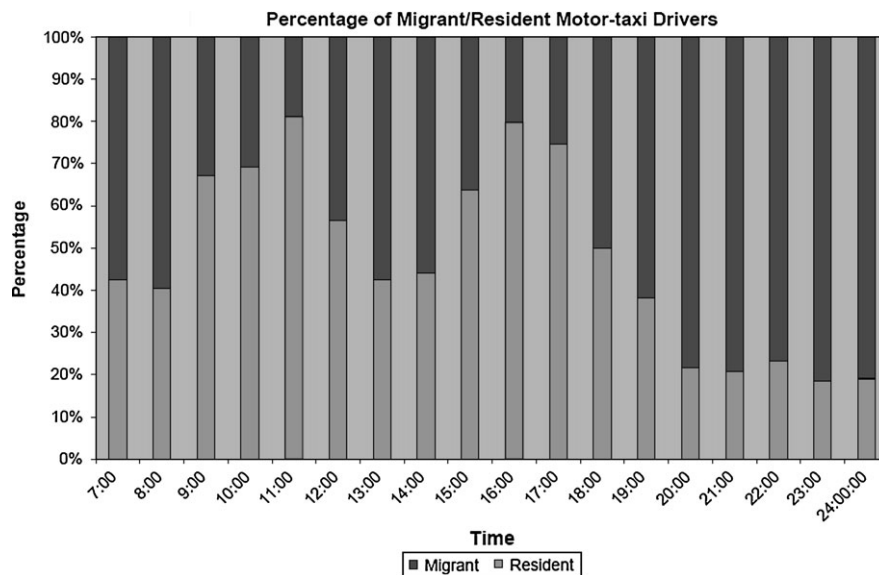


FIG. 8 Percentage of migrant/resident motorcycle taxi drivers in each hour

However, the peak time of robbery coincides with that of the migrant motorcycle taxi drivers' working time, as around 80 per cent of all taxis working at night are driven by migrant motorcyclists (Figure 8). Figure 8 shows the proportion of migrant and resident motorcycle taxi drivers in each hour from 7:00 to 24:00. We saw earlier (Figure 6) that

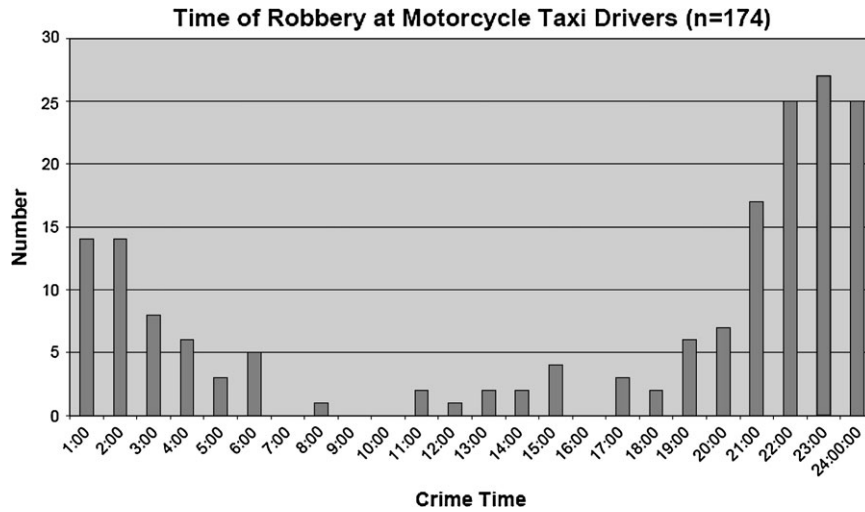


FIG. 9 Crime time of robbery against motorcycle taxi drivers from police records in 2006

the absolute numbers of migrant (52 per cent) and resident (48 per cent) motorcycle taxi drivers were fairly equally distributed. However, their activities take place at quite different times. Ideally, it would have been useful to have also obtained data about the working activities of motorcycle taxi drivers and figured out the proportions of migrant and resident motorcycle taxi drivers who put themselves out for hire between 1:00 and 6:00. However, it is dangerous for researchers to stay in the assigned observation posts late at night, as it is a 'golden time' for street crime. Fortunately, there is an alternative method that can be used to figure out who is working between 1:00 and 6:00. Interview data with motorcycle taxi drivers indicate that almost 90 per cent of motorcycle taxi drivers working after midnight are migrants. As Baoan, a migrant motorcycle taxi driver from Hebei province, who only worked at night, put it:

Usually, I start to come out at 19:00 and go back at 3:00, sometimes 5:00. Late at night, especially after midnight, more than 90 per cent of taxi drivers are migrants. (Baoan, 27)

Dalong, a local motorcyclist said similarly:

Late at night, more than 95 per cent of motorcycle taxi drivers are migrants. This might be explained by two reasons: one is to escape from the traffic police⁵ another is that their motorcycle might have some problems. Maybe they use fake licenses, or do not undergo mandatory annual checks (*nianjian*), or their machines are what are called 'dirty motorcycles' (*zangche*).⁶ (Dalong, 28, resident)

The differential risks of victimization between migrant and resident motorcycle taxi drivers can be fairly easily explained by their different patterns of working time. Working time mediates routine activity and the chance of victimization. The lifestyle/routine

⁵ Because of the motorcycle ban policy in Tianzhi city, it is illegal to drive non-local license motorcycles.

⁶ Dirty motorcycles (*zang che*) refer to motorcycles that are stolen by others and re-sold to taxi drivers.